

WHY ARE YOU READING THIS?

Only you can answer this question, of course. It could be for any number of reasons. Perhaps you have nothing else to do and the book fell open at this page or you're a real bookworm, determined to read this from cover to cover. A more general answer is that you are reading it to gain knowledge from the words written on the page. Keep on reading to discover more about knowledge and why you need it.

SHHH! READING IN PROGRESS

**"THERE IS MUCH PLEASURE
TO BE GAINED FROM
USELESS KNOWLEDGE."**

Bertrand Russell (1872-1970),
British philosopher

TRUE OR FALSE?

People don't always tell the truth, so ask yourself a few questions before you take someone's knowledge to be true. Has that person ever lied before? Can they back up their facts with evidence? Do other people accept their ideas as true? These tests work for knowledge gained from both books and people.

READING MATTERS

The most common way to get knowledge is by reading, whether it is an encyclopedia of reference facts or an adventure story of drama and excitement. Printed words are everywhere you look—on food labels, street signs, and the Internet. You spend many more minutes a day reading than you realize, and all of this reading tops off your memory stores with knowledge.

WHAT IS KNOWLEDGE?

Knowledge is what you learn about the world from your experiences and from other people. Your sense organs are constantly sending information to the brain. A tiny proportion is retained and stored in the brain as long-term memory—or knowledge.

SURVIVAL SKILLS

If you didn't have knowledge, you would still be as helpless as a baby and unable to take care of yourself. You need to know hundreds and thousands of things just to stay alive—that you have to eat every day, that hot things burn, that cars are dangerous—the list is endless. Without this knowledge, you wouldn't last very long at all.

